

GRIEF COUNSELLING

Unfortunately, grief is an inevitable, inescapable part of life.

We will all lose someone we love at some point in our life—most of us at many points—and the loss can often hit us harder than we expect.

If we feel really knocked off our feet or are struggling for a prolonged period of time, that may be a sign that we need some professional help to move on.

In this piece, we'll cover the basics of grief counseling/grief therapy and provide suggestions, tips, techniques, and exercises you can implement as a person in grieving, part of the support system for a person who is grieving, or as a mental health professional.

What is Grief Counseling? A Definition of the Basics

Before we get into defining grief counseling, let's start with a definition of grief.

Grief is...

"... a reaction to any form of loss... [that] encompass a range of feelings from deep sadness to anger, and the process of adapting to a significant loss can vary dramatically from one person to another, depending on his or her background, beliefs, relationship to what was lost, and other factors."

(Mastrangelo & Wood, 2016)

Although you may be most familiar with the idea of grief as a response to the death of a loved one, the definition given here is broader: "... a reaction to any form of loss" (emphasis mine). Thus, grief is something that can be experienced in a wide range of situations, including the death of a loved one or a pet, the dissolution of a marriage, estrangement with a family member, or any other kind of significant loss.

Grief counseling is intended to help the client grieve in a healthy manner, to understand and cope with the emotions they experience, and to ultimately find a way to move on (Therapy Tribe, n.d.). This can be accomplished through existential therapy, individual therapy, group therapy, and/or family therapy (Mastrangelo & Wood, 2016).

You are probably already familiar with one model of grief: Elisabeth Kübler-Ross' popular "Five Stages of Grief" model. Although not much evidence has been found to support this model, it has stuck around in popular culture. The five stages are:

1. Denial
2. Anger
3. Bargaining
4. Depression
5. Acceptance

Although Kübler-Ross initially proposed that everyone moves through each of the five stages once and only once, she later acknowledged that some people may only experience two stages and that some people may revisit stages later in life (Mastrangelo & Wood, 2016).

Another popular model comes from J. W. Worden, who proposed that humans must undergo the "Four Tasks of Mourning" to heal:

1. To accept the reality of the loss
 2. To work through the pain of grief
 3. To adjust to life without the deceased
 4. To maintain a connection to the deceased while moving on with life
- (Mastrangelo & Wood, 2016)

Although there are many unique theories and models of grieving with different stages and processes, generally all models agree that the following symptoms are common, whichever order they appear in:

- Shock and disbelief, feeling numb, even denial that the loss occurred
- Sadness, despair, loneliness, feeling empty
- Guilt, regret, shame
- Anger, feeling resentful
- Anxiety, helplessness, insecurity, fear
- Physical symptoms like fatigue, nausea, sickness, weight loss or gain, aches and pains, night sweats, heart palpitations, feeling faint or lightheaded, insomnia (Therapy Tribe, n.d.)

It's normal to experience these symptoms, but if you are experiencing them very intensely or for a long period of time after suffering the loss, you may want to look into grief counseling or grief therapy.

Grief Counseling and Grief Therapy: What's the Difference?

In general, the difference between counseling and therapy is merely one of semantics.

Both counseling and therapy use discussion between the client and the mental health professional to help the client address emotional, mental, or behavioral issues and solve problems.

However, the terms “counseling” and “therapy” are sometimes used in slightly different ways; counseling is more often used to refer to sessions focused on assisting clients who are dealing with everyday stressors and looking for ways to cope with normal issues and problems, while therapy is more frequently used to describe sessions in which clients are battling more difficult, more pervasive, and/or more chronic problems, like depression, anxiety, or addiction.

Thus, although grief counseling and grief therapy are basically the same thing, “grief counseling” may refer to the counseling that any individual might receive after losing a loved one, while “grief therapy” is more likely to refer to sessions that a client engages in when they are experiencing issues outside of the normal range of responses due to their grief.

For example, if a widow is simply struggling to cope with the loss of her husband, she may seek grief counseling; however, if she has lost her appetite and has had trouble sleeping for weeks, it may be a more serious problem that she seeks grief therapy for.

The Benefits of Grief Counseling

While grief counseling is not necessary for most people dealing with the loss of a loved one, there are some big potential benefits for those who are struggling more than usual (Mehta, 2013). If an individual was experiencing distress before the loss they suffered, or if their grief is chronic and interferes with normal functioning, grief counseling can help him or her to address their intense emotions and move on with the healing process.

Additionally, as with most forms of therapy, it is most effective if the individual voluntarily seeks it out.

Grief Counseling for Adults

If an individual does seek out grief counseling, this section describes what they can expect from their sessions.

The main goal of most grief counseling is to help the client integrate the reality of their loss into their life going forward, and helping them to maintain a healthy bond to the loved one they lost (Neimeyer, 2013). According to Dr. Robert A. Neimeyer, an active clinical psychologist and expert in grief therapy, there are two important first steps for working with a new client reeling from their loss:

1. Processing the Event Story of the Death

Clinicians working with a bereaved client will first encourage the client to engage in a healing re-telling of the loss. The clinician must create a safe space for the client to open up and build trust, so when the time comes to help the client rewrite the story of their loss, they are able to communicate effectively with the clinician.

2. Accessing the Back Story of the Relationship

In addition to hearing about the loss event itself, the clinician will also learn about the client's relationship with the loved one they lost. As Neimeyer says, "Death may end a life, but not necessarily a relationship." The clinician will guide the client through learning how to reconstruct their bond with their loved one rather than relinquishing it (Neimeyer, 2013).

Once you've got the basics covered, you can move on to some grief-specific techniques.

3 Techniques used in Grief Counseling

Three of the biggest things a good grief counselor can do for their client are to:

1. Let them talk about the deceased; ask them about the person, and allow them to speak about their lost loved one in a safe space.
2. Distinguish grief from trauma; if the client is struggling to get an image out of their head or experiencing flashbacks to the moment they learned of their loved one's death, they are experiencing trauma, which can keep them from working through their grief.

3. Deal with any guilt they are feeling and help them organize the grief; the client may feel guilty about what they did or didn't do while their loved one was alive, or they may feel guilty about not feeling "sad enough" or moving on while their loved one is dead. Encourage them to let go of the guilt and commit to living a life that will honor the deceased, even if that means forgetting about them for a little while (Tyrrell, n.d.).

Interventions and Strategies in Grief Therapy

Aside from the three important techniques listed above, there are many other more specific interventions and modified strategies that can be used to support a client in grief therapy.

For example, Dr. Alan D. Wolfelt developed the Companioning Model of Bereavement caregiving, in which the counselor or therapist acts as a companion and helper for the client. He is present for his client and observes their experience; however, "observe" in this context doesn't mean just watching, but bearing witness to their experience and to watch out for them.

Companioning is about...

- Honoring the spirit, not focusing on the intellect.
- Curiosity, not expertise.
- Learning from others, not teaching them.
- Walking alongside, not leading.
- Being still, not frantic movement forward.
- Discovering the gifts of sacred silence, not about filling every painful moment with words.
- Listening with the heart, not analyzing with the head.
- Bearing witness to the struggles of others, not directing them.
- Being present to another person's pain, not taking away the pain.
- Respecting disorder and confusion, not imposing order and logic.
- Going to the wilderness of the soul with another human being, not thinking you are responsible for finding the way out (Wheeler-Roy & Amyot, 2004).

Following this model, the counselor or therapist will:

- Listen in a supportive manner to the client's concerns.
- Help disaster survivors recognize that, in most cases, their emotional reactions are natural, normal, and to be expected.

- Assist survivors to reduce additional stress by organizing and prioritizing day-to-day and recovery-related tasks.
- Help individuals to understand and recognize the wide range of reactions to trauma, such as numbness, frustration, confusion, anger, anxiety, sadness, and feelings of helplessness.
- Assist individuals to draw on their own strengths and develop healthy coping mechanisms that permit them to gradually resume their pre-disaster (or pre-loss) level of functioning.
- Sensitively and caringly help individuals to grieve their losses in their own unique ways.
- Systematically draw upon an array of recovery resources for appropriate referrals (Wheeler-Roy & Amyot, 2004)

Dr. Kenneth Doka recommends encouraging clients to use rituals to connect with their loved one and carry on despite their grief. These four types of rituals can help:

1. Rituals of Continuity – These rituals establish that the lost loved one is still a part of the client's life, that the bond is still there.
2. Rituals of Transition – This type of ritual marks a significant change that has occurred in the grief response, such as cleaning out the room of the deceased or donating their belongings.
3. Rituals of Affirmation – In this ritual, the client can discharge any built-up regret by writing a letter or a poem to the deceased thanking them for their love and support.
4. Rituals of Intensification – These rituals connect group members and reinforce their common identity; a military unit may gather periodically to remember their fallen comrades or the survivors of an act of violence may revisit the site and place flowers or erect a memorial to those they lost (Wheeler-Roy & Amyot, 2004).

Smaller, everyday rituals can also be helpful for those grieving a loss; these are called Rituals to Commemorate, and include things like lighting a candle and thinking of the loved one, watching home videos or going through old pictures of the loved one, traveling to a place the loved one always wanted to visit, or visiting the burial site and leaving a tribute or symbolic item, like flowers or a balloon.

The mental health professional will not always encourage or apply the same techniques equally; there are a million different ways to grieve, and every healthy method of grieving is valid. However, there are two poles in grieving, with people

falling anywhere on the spectrum between. The poles are “Intuitive Griever” and “Instrumental Griever.”

The Intuitive Griever experiences feelings associated with their grief intensely and is open with expressions of their grief (e.g., crying, lamenting their loss). For them, successful strategies to cope with their grief involve facilitating their experience and expressing their feelings.

They may experience prolonged periods of confusion, inability to concentrate, disorganization, and disorientation, and they might also suffer from physical exhaustion and/or anxiety.

On the other hand, the Instrumental Griever is more prone to thoughts of grief than feelings of grief and is often reluctant to talk about their feelings. They prioritize mastery of themselves and their environment and find success in problem-solving strategies. They may experience brief periods of cognitive dysfunction, like confusion, forgetfulness, and obsessiveness, and they may have increased energy levels (Wheeler-Roy & Amyot, 2004).

Tips for Coping with Grief

In addition to the techniques and strategies listed above, counselors will likely also offer the following three tips for those who are grieving.

1. Do not grieve alone

It's vital that you stay connected with others during this time. Your support system may include your family, friends, leaders in your faith, a bereavement support group, and/or a licensed mental health professional to help you cope.

Your support system can help you:

- Make the funeral arrangements or help you with new responsibilities.
- Find peace and comfort through your faith's mourning rituals.
- Share your grief with others who can relate.
- Work through your difficult emotions in a safe setting.

2. Take good care of yourself

It can be easy to forget about our own needs when we are reeling from loss, but neglecting yourself won't help you effectively deal with your grief.

Remember to:

- Do something creative to express your feelings (e.g., write something, paint, put together a scrapbook, or play a musical instrument).
- Eat, sleep, and exercise to avoid adding physical fatigue to your emotional fatigue.
- Be patient with yourself and allow yourself to feel whatever you feel.
- Understand what triggers your grief and prepare for those triggers (e.g., plan to take a day or two off of work, let your friends and family know you'll need extra support, etc.).

3. Seek professional grief counseling

Not everyone will need the services of a counselor or therapist during their grieving period, but it can be very helpful for those who are really struggling. A qualified professional can help you understand the grief process and give you the tools you need to cope with your emotions (Therapy Tribe, n.d.).

While everyone grieves differently, these three tips are essential for anyone who must cope with a profound loss.

Coping with Miscarriage

As common as miscarriages are, they can still generate enormous feelings of loss and grief in expectant parents (and others heavily invested in the pregnancy, such as grandparents of the child lost).

It is absolutely normal to experience grief after a miscarriage, whenever it occurs in the pregnancy; however, recent research shows that around 15% of women who experience miscarriages suffer from more serious grief-related symptoms that may require the assistance of a qualified mental health professional (Leis-Newman, 2012).

If you are suffering from the symptoms below over a long period of time or to the point that you cannot function normally, you may want to look into counseling or therapy for your loss.

After a miscarriage, the sufferer may experience:

- Depression
- Numbness and disbelief
- Anger
- Guilt
- Sadness
- Difficulty concentrating
- Fatigue
- Trouble Sleeping
- Loss of appetite
- Frequent episodes of crying
- Broken or suffering relationships with family or friends
- Self-harm/suicidal attempts or actions (American Pregnancy Association, n.d.)

A common post-miscarriage grieving process may unfold in the following manner:

1. Shock or denial that the miscarriage happened.
2. Anger, guilt, and/or depression; feeling that it isn't fair, or asking "Why me?"
3. Acceptance of the reality of the miscarriage.

Getting to step three doesn't mean the grieving process is done, but it means you have accepted your situation and you now understand what you're dealing with; from here, it can get much, much better.

To help you along your grieving process, remember to:

- Reach out to your loved ones for understanding, support, and comfort.
- Seek counseling if you need it, and encourage your partner to seek counseling if he or she needs it; know that you are not alone.
- Give yourself the time, space, and permission to grieve and remember what you have lost.
- Set realistic goals for yourself, and focus on one thing at a time.
- Allow yourself to feel both grief and joy; celebrating brief moments of joy does not dishonor your loss (American Pregnancy Association, n.d.).

While you are grieving your loss, it can be all too easy to focus on your own grief and ignore your partner's experience. This is dangerous to the health of your relationship and should be avoided at all costs. To help your relationship survive the grieving process, be sure to:

- Be respectful and sensitive to your partner's needs, as they should be to yours.
- Keep the communication lines open and share your thoughts and emotions with one another.

- Accept the differences in coping styles and acknowledge the other's coping process as valid (American Pregnancy Association, n.d.).

Coping with a miscarriage is a heart-wrenching and difficult process, but know that you are not alone and there are tons of people out there who have suffered the same loss, and tons of support available.